

Challenge 3: Caccetta–Häggkvist Conjecture

Definition 1 (Digraph). A *digraph* D consists of a finite nonempty set $V(D)$ of vertices and a set $A(D) \subseteq V(D) \times V(D)$ of arcs with $(v, v) \notin A(D)$ for every vertex v . Thus D has no loops and no multiple arcs, while arcs in both directions between two vertices are allowed. The *out-degree* $d^+(v)$ of a vertex v is the number of arcs $(v, w) \in A(D)$, and the *minimum out-degree* of D is the smallest out-degree of a vertex of D .

Definition 2 (Directed cycle). A *directed cycle of length $\ell \geq 2$* in a digraph D is a sequence $v_0, \dots, v_{\ell-1}$ of distinct vertices such that $(v_i, v_{i+1}) \in A(D)$ for every i , where the indices are taken modulo ℓ .

Conjecture 1.1 (Caccetta–Häggkvist Conjecture [1]). Let $r \in \mathbb{N}$ with $r \geq 1$. Every digraph on n vertices with minimum out-degree at least r contains a directed cycle of length at most $\lceil n/r \rceil$.

For $r = 1$ the statement is elementary: following out-arcs from any vertex must eventually revisit a vertex, which yields a directed cycle, of length at most n . The conjecture was proved for $r = 2$ by Caccetta and Häggkvist [1], for $r = 3$ by Hamidoune [2], and for $r = 4$ and $r = 5$ by Hoàng and Reed [3]. Shen proved it for every r under the additional assumption $n \geq 2r^2 - 3r + 1$ [4]. When r is a constant fraction of n , the conjecture predicts that minimum out-degree at least $n/3$ forces a directed cycle of length at most 3; it is known that minimum out-degree at least $(3 - \sqrt{7})n \approx 0.354n$ suffices [5]. See [6] for an overview.

The challenge parameter is the minimum out-degree r . The first open case is $r = 6$.

References

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